THE WHOLE STORY · SMALL GROUP GUIDE · LESSON 3 OF 26

Creation and the Image of God

Genesis 1–2 · Psalm 8

> **The big idea:** God made everything out of nothing by his word and called it very good. Then he set his own living image in it, man and woman, made to know him, reflect him, and rule his world. Jesus is the true Image, and he restores ours.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 1:1–2:3 | Genesis 2:4–25 | Psalm 8 | Hebrews 2:5–9 | Colossians 1:15–17

Open (5 minutes)

What do people around you seem to think human beings are for? What would you have said a few years ago?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

And God _____, "Let there be light," and there was light. *(Genesis 1:3)*

"So God created man in his own _____, in the image of God he created him; _____ and female he created them." *(Genesis 1:27)*

"And God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very _____." *(Genesis 1:31)*

"Then the LORD God formed the man of _____ from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the _____ of life." *(Genesis 2:7)*

"The LORD God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to _____ it and _____ it." *(Genesis 2:15)*

"He is the _____ of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation." *(Colossians 1:15)*

Discuss

1. Our culture says people are for being happy, for achieving, or for being true to themselves. How does Genesis 1–2 answer the question differently? *Genesis 1:26–28*

2. On the first three days God forms; on the next three he fills. What does that pattern tell you about the God who made the world? *Genesis 1:1–2:3*

3. God called the physical world very good. Where have you seen people, even Christians, treat the body or the material world as less than good? *Genesis 1:31; 1 Timothy 4:4*

4. Read Genesis 9:6 and James 3:9. How should God's image shape the way we treat the unborn, the disabled, the elderly, people of other races, and our enemies? *Genesis 9:6; James 3:9*

5. Work, marriage, and rest were all given before sin entered the world. Which of the three is hardest for you to receive as a gift? Why? *Genesis 2:2–3, 15, 18–24*

6. Hebrews admits, "At present, we do not yet see everything in subjection to him." Then it says, "But we see him." How is Jesus the answer to Psalm 8? *Psalm 8:3–6; Hebrews 2:8–9*

Apply this week

Pick one person you find hard to love. Each time you see them this week, tell yourself silently: a living statue of the King. Then keep the Lord's Day this Sunday. Worship with God's people and rest from your ordinary work, and receive the day as a gift.

Memory verse

"So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them."

Genesis 1:27

Pray

Thank God that he made you on purpose and in his image, and that he called his world very good. Confess the ways you have defaced that image. Ask him to make you more like Jesus, the true Image.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 3

Creation and the Image of God

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 1:26–2:3 and Genesis 2:7–25 aloud together. Then read Psalm 8.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the forming and filling chart and the three parts of the image (WSC 10) in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 4 (Genesis 3; Romans 5:12–21).

Main points to land

1. God made everything out of nothing by his word, in an ordered pattern of forming and filling, and called it very good (Genesis 1; Hebrews 11:3; WSC 9).
2. The material world is good. Bodies, food, work, marriage, and rest are gifts made through Christ and for him (Genesis 1:31; Colossians 1:16; 1 Timothy 4:4).
3. Man and woman are made in God's image: to reflect his knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, to rule his world under him, and to bear the image together (Genesis 1:26–28; WSC 10). Every human life has dignity (Genesis 9:6).
4. In the garden God gave Adam work, a command, a wife, and rest. The command was the covenant of works, with Adam standing as head of the human race (Genesis 2:15–17; WCF 7.2).
5. We do not yet see the world under man's feet, but we see Jesus, the true Image, who restores God's image in all who trust him (Hebrews 2:8–9; Colossians 1:15; 2 Corinthians 3:18).

Answer key (Observe)

1. said
2. image; male
3. good
4. dust; breath
5. work; keep
6. image

Questions people will ask

Were the days of Genesis 1 ordinary 24-hour days?
This study takes them as ordinary days, and the Westminster Confession says God created in the space of six days (WCF 4.1; see Exodus 20:11). Faithful Reformed teachers have also read them as long ages or as a literary framework. All of them hold that God made everything out of nothing, by his word, and that Adam was a real man. Keep the group on that main point.

Who is the "us" in "Let us make man"?
Genesis does not fully explain it. Many Christians since the early church have seen a first hint of the Trinity, which the New Testament opens up: all things were made through the Son (John 1:3; Colossians 1:16), and the Spirit was hovering over the waters (Genesis 1:2). Some read it as God speaking with angels, but angels did not create, and man is made in God's image, not theirs.

Does everyone bear God's image, even people who reject him?
Yes. Genesis 9:6 and James 3:9 speak of God's image in people after the fall. Sin defaced the image but did not erase it. Only in Christ is it renewed in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness (Colossians 3:10; Ephesians 4:24). So every person has dignity, and every person needs Christ.

If work was given before the fall, why is my job so hard?
Work itself is good. The thorns and frustration came with the fall, which is next week's lesson (Genesis 3:17–19). In Christ, ordinary work can be done for God again, as worship. Let people be honest about hard jobs without calling work itself a curse.

Closing prayer

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, you made all things out of nothing, and you made us in your image to know you and to show your glory in your world. We confess that we have defaced that image. Thank you for Jesus, the true Image, who lived the life we were made for and died for our sin. Renew us after his likeness, and teach us to honor your image in every person we meet. Amen.